# The AI Automation Starter Checklist

A first AI workflow succeeds when it is small, measurable and has a person in charge of it. This checklist takes you through seven steps, from choosing the process to proving it worked.

It is written for business owners and operations leads, not engineers. Work through it with the person who does the task today. If you cannot tick most of a step, pause there before spending money on a build.

## Step 1: Pick the right first workflow

The best first workflow is frequent, repetitive and low-risk if it goes wrong. Avoid starting with your most complicated or most sensitive process.

- [ ] The task happens at least several times a week
- [ ] It follows roughly the same steps each time
- [ ] The inputs are digital (emails, forms, PDFs, records), not phone calls or paper
- [ ] A mistake can be caught and corrected before it reaches a customer or a payment
- [ ] One person can describe the whole process from start to finish
- [ ] The team doing the task wants it automated

Good first candidates: invoice data entry, replies to inbound enquiries, support ticket sorting, CRM updates after calls, weekly report preparation.

## Step 2: Scope it on one page

Write the workflow down before anyone builds it. If it does not fit on one page, it is too big for a first project.

- [ ] Trigger: what starts the workflow (an email arrives, a form is submitted)
- [ ] Inputs: what information comes in, and in what format
- [ ] Steps: what happens today, in order, including the exceptions
- [ ] Output: what a finished task looks like and where it is recorded
- [ ] Tools: every system the workflow reads from or writes to
- [ ] Owner: one named person responsible for the workflow after launch
- [ ] Out of scope: what this first version will not handle

## Step 3: Ask the data questions

Get these answers in writing from whoever builds the workflow, whether that is your own team or a supplier.

- [ ] Which data does the workflow need, and can it work with less?
- [ ] Does it include personal, financial or health information?
- [ ] Which AI provider processes the data, and in which region?
- [ ] Is our data used to train the provider's models? Where is that stated?
- [ ] How long is data kept, and how is it deleted?
- [ ] Who can see the data and the logs, including at the supplier?
- [ ] Which laws or client contracts apply (for example GDPR), and has our adviser confirmed the setup?

## Step 4: Decide where a person approves

Let the AI prepare the work and let a person approve anything that is hard to undo. You can loosen the rules later, once you have results to judge by.

| Action | Suggested rule for a first workflow |
|---|---|
| Reading, sorting, summarising | Automatic |
| Drafting a reply or a record | Automatic draft, person sends or saves |
| Sending a message to a customer | Person approves |
| Changing money, prices or payments | Person approves, always |
| Deleting or overwriting records | Person approves, always |
| Anything the AI marks as uncertain | Goes to a person |

- [ ] Every action in the workflow has a rule from the table
- [ ] Approvers are named, with a backup for holidays
- [ ] There is a clear way to stop the workflow quickly

## Step 5: Test before launch

Test on real past examples, with the pass mark agreed before testing starts.

- [ ] A test set of real past cases, including awkward ones (aim for at least 30)
- [ ] The correct answer recorded for each case
- [ ] A pass mark agreed in advance, such as the share of cases handled correctly
- [ ] Failure cases tested: missing data, unreadable files, unusual requests
- [ ] The person who does the task today has reviewed the results
- [ ] The same test set is kept to re-run after every change

## Step 6: Launch in stages and monitor

Start with a small share of the work and widen it only when the results hold.

- [ ] Stage 1: the workflow runs alongside the team, and nothing it produces is used yet
- [ ] Stage 2: it handles a small share of real work, with every item reviewed
- [ ] Stage 3: it handles most of the work, with spot checks
- [ ] Every action is logged: what came in, what the AI did, who approved
- [ ] Alerts go to the owner when errors or unusual volumes appear
- [ ] Running cost is tracked each month
- [ ] A fallback exists: the team can do the task by hand if the workflow is switched off

## Step 7: Measure before and after

Record the numbers before launch, or you will not be able to show what changed.

| Measure | Before | After 30 days | After 90 days |
|---|---|---|---|
| Tasks per week | | | |
| Minutes per task | | | |
| Time to first response | | | |
| Error or rework rate | | | |
| Share needing human correction | | | |
| Monthly running cost | | | |

- [ ] Baseline numbers recorded before launch
- [ ] A review date set for 30 and 90 days after launch
- [ ] A decision rule agreed: expand, adjust or stop

## Warning signs

Stop and rethink if any of these apply.

- Nobody can explain the current process the same way twice
- The plan is to automate everything at once
- There is no named owner after launch
- A supplier cannot answer the data questions in Step 3
- The AI would act on money or customer records with no approval step
- Success is described only as "using AI", with no number attached

## Next step

If you would like a second opinion on your first workflow, SquarFinity offers a free 30-minute AI workflow assessment. We map one of your processes against this checklist and tell you where AI fits and where it does not.

Book at squarfinity.com/consult